

A FINITE ELEMENT STOKES SOLVER FOR GLACIER FLOW

ED BUELER

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This document, for the International Summer School in Glaciology in McCarthy, Alaska, describes a numerical model for glacier ice flow, written in short Python codes, exploiting these open source tools and libraries:

- Firedrake, a finite element library <https://www.firedrakeproject.org/>
- Gmsh, a mesh generator <http://gmsh.info/>
- Paraview, a visualization tool <https://www.paraview.org/>

To start we state the Glen-Stokes continuum model for 2D ice flow, with glacier-suitable boundary conditions. The slab-on-a-slope case has an exact solution, so we address that special case first. (This solution is also used as a source of boundary conditions for other cases.) We then derive the weak form of the Stokes problem and give a brief overview of finite element (FE) methods. Our particular FE method uses an unstructured mesh of triangular elements to solve the Glen-Stokes problem by a stable “mixed” method with distinct approximating spaces for velocity and pressure. The solver works for a variety of ice geometries, for example with a bedrock step as shown in Figure 1, which is the default case. We demonstrate numerical solutions and give a brief guide to usage.

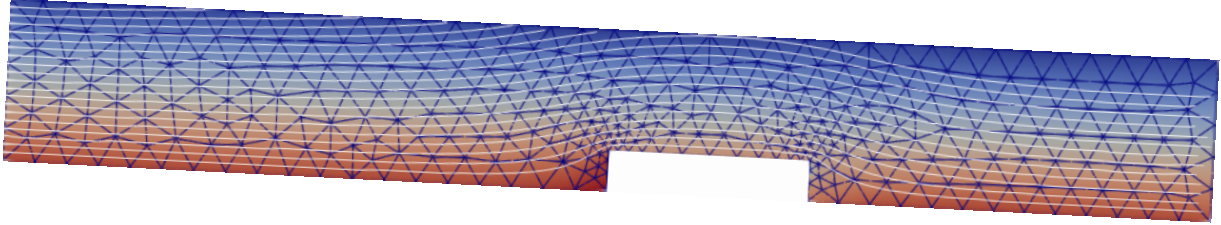


FIGURE 1. A 2D glacier flowing over a bedrock step. Streamlines show velocity $\mathbf{u}$, and shading is by pressure p .

1. GLEN-STOKES MODEL

Let us start from the Glen-Stokes model for ice dynamics. This model, also covered in [9, 10], applies on any 2D or 3D domain Ω which has a piecewise smooth boundary. Allowing any Glen exponent $n \geq 1$, the equations are:

$$-\nabla \cdot \tau + \nabla p = \rho \mathbf{g} \quad \text{stress balance} \quad (1)$$

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0 \quad \text{incompressibility} \quad (2)$$

$$D\mathbf{u} = A_n |\tau|^{n-1} \tau \quad \text{Glen flow law} \quad (3)$$

The notation here generally follows my notes and slides, including velocity $\mathbf{u}$, pressure p , ice density ρ , acceleration of gravity $\mathbf{g}$, deviatoric stress tensor τ , strain rate tensor $D\mathbf{u}$,

and ice softness A_n . A key idea is that tensors $D\mathbf{u}$ and τ are symmetric (conservation of angular momentum) and have trace zero (incompressibility). Note that $D\mathbf{u}$ is the symmetric part of the velocity derivative tensor $\nabla\mathbf{u}$:

$$(D\mathbf{u})_{ij} = \frac{1}{2} (\nabla\mathbf{u} + \nabla\mathbf{u}^\top) = \frac{1}{2} ((u_i)_{x_j} + (u_j)_{x_i}) \quad (4)$$

The full (Cauchy) stress tensor σ is the deviatoric stress tensor τ minus the pressure,

$$\sigma = \tau - pI, \quad (5)$$

so equation (1) simply says $-\nabla \cdot \sigma = \rho\mathbf{g}$. One may derive from (5) that $p = -\frac{1}{2} \text{tr } \sigma$ (in 2D), thus the pressure is the negative of the average normal stress. By definition $\nabla \cdot \tau$ in (1) is a vector with components which are the divergences of the columns:

$$(\nabla \cdot \tau)_i = (\tau_{1i})_{x_1} + (\tau_{2i})_{x_2} \quad (6)$$

Note $\nabla \cdot \tau$, ∇p , and $\mathbf{g}$ are regarded as column vectors.

The viscosity form of (3) can also be found in the notes:

$$\tau = 2\nu D\mathbf{u} = B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u} \quad (7)$$

Here $B_n = (A_n)^{-1/n}$ is the ice hardness in units $\text{Pa s}^{1/n}$. The tensor norm notation used in (3) and (7) is defined as follows, with the summation convention:

$$|\tau|^2 = \frac{1}{2} \text{tr } (\tau^2) = \frac{1}{2} \tau_{ij} \tau_{ij}, \quad |D\mathbf{u}|^2 = \frac{1}{2} \text{tr } ((D\mathbf{u})^2) = \frac{1}{2} (D\mathbf{u})_{ij} (D\mathbf{u})_{ij}$$

Using (7) we can eliminate τ from equation (1), thereby rewriting the system in terms of velocity $\mathbf{u}$ and pressure p only:

$$-\nabla \cdot \left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u} \right) + \nabla p = \rho\mathbf{g} \quad (8)$$

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0 \quad (9)$$

From now on we denote the points of the 2D region Ω by (x, z) , and we add an angle parameter: gravity is at an angle α with the z -direction, so that $\mathbf{g} = \langle g \sin \alpha, -g \cos \alpha \rangle$ where $g > 0$. The numerical model in these notes solves system (8), (9) with a body force given by this $\rho\mathbf{g}$. A solution of the problem is a pair $(\mathbf{u}, p)$.

Certain glacier-suitable velocity and stress boundary conditions will be used here. We assume that base, top, inflow, and outflow boundaries can all be identified. On the base we require no slip:

$$\mathbf{u} = 0 \quad \text{base} \quad (10)$$

(Modifying this is not too difficult, and is an excellent exercise.) On the top we set a condition of zero applied stress, $\sigma \hat{\mathbf{n}} = 0$:

$$\left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u} - pI \right) \hat{\mathbf{n}} = 0 \quad \text{top} \quad (11)$$

The inflow boundary is the left side, which has outward normal $\hat{\mathbf{n}} = \langle -1, 0 \rangle$, and here we set a nonzero inflow velocity:

$$\mathbf{u} = \langle f(z), 0 \rangle \quad \text{inflow} \quad (12)$$

The implemented function $f(z)$ satisfies the slab-on-slope equations for a given thickness H_{in} ; see below. On the outflow boundary, which is the right side and has $\hat{\mathbf{n}} = \langle 1, 0 \rangle$ in the implemented form, we set a nonzero hydrostatic normal stress using the ice thickness H_{out} at that location:

$$\begin{aligned} \left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u} - pI \right) \hat{\mathbf{n}} = & \langle -\rho g \cos \alpha (H_{\text{out}} - z), \\ & \rho g \sin \alpha (H_{\text{out}} - z) \rangle \quad \text{outflow} \end{aligned} \quad (13)$$

2. SLAB-ON-SLOPE SOLUTIONS

Testing a numerical model requires verification tools, namely exact solutions. Such solutions are in short supply for the Glen-Stokes model, but we have the slab-on-slope case, and it allows any Glen exponent n . This exact solution also generates inflow and outflow boundary conditions which can be used for other cases.

Using component notation for 2D, equations (8) and (9) become the following equations in coordinates (x, z) and velocity components $\mathbf{u} = \langle u, w \rangle$:

$$-\left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} u_x \right)_x - \left(\frac{1}{2} B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} (u_z + w_x) \right)_z + p_x = \rho g \sin \alpha \quad (14)$$

$$-\left(\frac{1}{2} B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} (u_z + w_x) \right)_x - \left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} w_z \right)_z + p_z = -\rho g \cos \alpha \quad (15)$$

$$u_x + w_z = 0 \quad (16)$$

The strain-rate norm expands to

$$|D\mathbf{u}|^2 = \frac{1}{2} \left(u_x^2 + \frac{1}{2} (u_z + w_x)^2 + w_z^2 \right) \quad (17)$$

Consider either an infinitely-long or a periodic slab flow which has x -independent values of the bed elevation b and the surface elevation s . The domain is $\Omega = \{(x, z) \mid b < z < s\}$. Assume that the boundary stresses are also x -independent. Then there is no variation in x , i.e. $\partial/\partial x = 0$, so the system simplifies:

$$-\left(\frac{1}{2} B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} u_z \right)_z = \rho g \sin \alpha \quad (18)$$

$$p_z = -\rho g \cos \alpha \quad (19)$$

$$w_z = 0 \quad (20)$$

From the (20) and (17) the strain-rate norm simplifies to $|D\mathbf{u}| = \frac{1}{2}|u_z|$. If we further assume that there is no melt or freeze at the base then $w = 0$ identically, and now the ice velocity is bed and surface parallel. Now an integration of (19) with respect to z , and assumption of zero pressure at the surface, yields hydrostatic pressure:

$$p(z) = \rho g (\cos \alpha) (s - z) \quad (21)$$

Equation (18) now yields a single nontrivial equation for the horizontal velocity:

$$-\left(\frac{B_n}{2^{1/n}} |u_z|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} u_z \right)_z = \rho g \sin \alpha \quad (22)$$

From the expected shear direction $u_z > 0$, rearrangement gives

$$\left((u_z)^{1/n}\right)_z = -\frac{2^{1/n}\rho g \sin \alpha}{B_n} \quad (23)$$

This can be vertically-integrated downward from the surface $z = s$, using the no-stress condition (11), which simplifies to $u_z = 0$, to give

$$u_z = 2 \left(\frac{\rho g \sin \alpha}{B_n} \right)^n (s - z)^n \quad (24)$$

Integrating vertically again, upward from the base $z = b$ where $u = 0$, gives

$$u(z) = \frac{2}{n+1} \left(\frac{\rho g \sin \alpha}{B_n} \right)^n \left((s - b)^{n+1} - (s - z)^{n+1} \right) \quad (25)$$

This derivation is complete. Formulas (21) and (25) exactly solve the Stokes equations and the given boundary conditions.

These slab-on-slope formulas allow us to set glaciologically-reasonable boundary conditions for more general shapes like that shown in Figure 1. In the implemented cases, the inflow side has (25) applied as a Dirichlet condition, so $f(z)$ in (12) is determined. On the outflow side we apply a normal stress derived from (24). That is, using the facts that $w = 0$, $u_x = 0$, $|D\mathbf{u}| = \frac{1}{2}u_z$, and $\hat{\mathbf{n}} = \langle 1, 0 \rangle$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma \hat{\mathbf{n}} &= \left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u} - pI \right) \hat{\mathbf{n}} = \left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} \begin{pmatrix} u_x & \frac{1}{2}(u_z + w_x) \\ \frac{1}{2}(u_z + w_x) & w_z \end{pmatrix} - pI \right) \hat{\mathbf{n}} \\ &= B_n \left(\frac{1}{2}u_z \right)^{\frac{1}{n}-1} \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \frac{1}{2}u_z \end{pmatrix} - \begin{pmatrix} p \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -p \\ \frac{B_n}{2^{1/n}}(u_z)^{1/n} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -\rho g \cos \alpha (h - z) \\ \rho g \sin \alpha (h - z) \end{pmatrix} \end{aligned}$$

This justifies formula (13).

3. WEAK FORM

Equations (8) and (9) are called the *strong form* of the Glen-Stokes model. An integral equation form of the same equations, the *weak form*, is needed when building a numerical finite element (FE) method [6]. This new form will be derived by multiplying the strong form equations by test functions and then integrating over Ω , which defines a nonlinear functional F , that is, a function which takes functions as input and returns scalars. The weak form says that F is zero when acting on test functions. The significance of the weak form can be stated in several ways:

- It is well-posed in the sense of always having a unique solution for glaciologically-relevant boundary values [10].
- It has a larger space of potential solutions than the strong form, for instance it is more flexible with respect to discontinuities in the data.
- An FE method can create test functions via local constructions which work on a mesh of triangles or quadrilaterals, and these piecewise-defined functions are allowed in the weak form. This framework is more flexible with respect to problem geometry than finite difference methods based on the strong form.

A solution to the weak form below is a velocity-pressure pair $(\mathbf{u}, p)$. Each function lives in a certain function space. We write $\mathbf{u} \in V_D$ and $p \in Q$, and the Sobolev spaces V_D and Q are precisely-identified in [10]. Test functions $\mathbf{v} \in V_0$ and $q \in Q$ come from nearly

the same spaces, with V_D and V_0 differing only by the value on the Dirichlet boundary: $\mathbf{u} \in V_D$ satisfies a nonhomogeneous inflow condition (12) while $\mathbf{v} \in V_0$ is zero there.

To give a preliminary definition of F we multiply (8) by $\mathbf{v} \in V_0$ and (9) by $q \in Q$, then add and integrate:

$$F(\mathbf{u}, p; \mathbf{v}, q) = \int_{\Omega} - \left(\nabla \cdot \left(B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u} \right) \right) \cdot \mathbf{v} + \nabla p \cdot \mathbf{v} - \rho \mathbf{g} \cdot \mathbf{v} - (\nabla \cdot \mathbf{u}) q \quad (26)$$

However, the actual definition of F re-balances the number of derivatives on $(\mathbf{v}, q)$ versus $(\mathbf{u}, p)$, to have only first derivatives on $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}$, and no derivative on p, q . For this we need integration-by-parts.

Recall the product rule $\nabla \cdot (f\mathbf{X}) = \nabla f \cdot \mathbf{X} + f \nabla \cdot \mathbf{X}$ and the divergence theorem $\int_{\Omega} \nabla \cdot (f\mathbf{X}) = \int_{\partial\Omega} f\mathbf{X} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{n}}$. Denoting $\tau = B_n |D\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} D\mathbf{u}$ for convenience we have

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{\Omega} (\nabla \cdot \tau) \cdot \mathbf{v} &= \sum_{j=1}^2 \int_{\Omega} \nabla \cdot (\tau_{j\circ}) v_j = \sum_{j=1}^2 \int_{\Omega} \nabla \cdot (\tau_{j\circ} v_j) - \tau_{j\circ} \nabla v_j \\ &= \sum_{j=1}^2 \int_{\partial\Omega} (\tau_{j\circ} v_j) \cdot \hat{\mathbf{n}} - \int_{\Omega} \tau_{j\circ} \cdot \nabla v_j = \int_{\partial\Omega} (\tau \hat{\mathbf{n}}) \cdot \mathbf{v} - \int_{\Omega} \text{tr}(\tau \nabla \mathbf{v}) \end{aligned}$$

where $\circ$ denotes a vector entry index and $\tau_{j\circ}$ denotes the j th row of τ . Here $\nabla \mathbf{v}$ defines a 2×2 matrix,

$$\nabla \mathbf{v} = \left[\begin{array}{c|c} \nabla v_1 & \nabla v_2 \end{array} \right] = \begin{bmatrix} (v_1)_{x_1} & (v_2)_{x_1} \\ (v_1)_{x_2} & (v_2)_{x_2} \end{bmatrix}$$

and so

$$\text{tr}(\tau \nabla \mathbf{v}) = \sum_{j=1}^3 \tau_{j\circ} \cdot \nabla v_j = \sum_{i,j=1}^3 \tau_{ji} (v_j)_{x_i}$$

(Some sources write $A : B$ for $\text{tr}(AB)$ [10].) Note $\text{tr}(\tau \nabla \mathbf{v}) = \text{tr}(\tau D\mathbf{v})$ because $\text{tr}(AB) = 0$ if A is symmetric and B is antisymmetric. (To show this take $A = \tau$ and $B = \nabla \mathbf{v} - D\mathbf{v}$.) Finally we do a straightforward integration-by-parts on the pressure part of F :

$$\int_{\Omega} \nabla p \cdot \mathbf{v} = \int_{\Omega} \nabla \cdot (p \mathbf{v}) - p(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{v}) = \int_{\partial\Omega} p \hat{\mathbf{n}} \cdot \mathbf{v} - \int_{\Omega} p(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{v})$$

The above facts allow us to rewrite (26) with a normal stress boundary integral:

$$F(\mathbf{u}, p; \mathbf{v}, q) = \int_{\Omega} [\text{tr}(\tau D\mathbf{v}) - p(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{v}) - (\nabla \cdot \mathbf{u}) q - \rho \mathbf{g} \cdot \mathbf{v}] - \int_{\partial\Omega} (\sigma \hat{\mathbf{n}}) \cdot \mathbf{v} \quad (27)$$

(We have denoted $\sigma = \tau - pI$ for brevity.) In this not-quite-final form of the functional, note that $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}$ appear with first derivatives and p, q have no derivatives.

Next recall that test functions $\mathbf{v} \in V_0$ satisfy $\mathbf{v} = 0$ along the base and inflow surfaces. Thus these parts of the integral over $\partial\Omega$ in (27) are zero. Conditions (11), (13) now completely eliminate the unknown solution $\mathbf{u}, p$ from the boundary integral. The above

computations yield our final formula for the nonlinear functional:

$$F(\mathbf{u}, p; \mathbf{v}, q) = \int_{\Omega} B_n |\mathbf{D}\mathbf{u}|^{\frac{1}{n}-1} \text{tr}(\mathbf{D}\mathbf{u}\mathbf{D}\mathbf{v}) - p(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{v}) - (\nabla \cdot \mathbf{u})q \\ - \int_{\Omega} \rho \mathbf{g} \cdot \mathbf{v} - \int_{\{\text{outflow}\}} \rho g \cos \alpha (h - z)v \quad (28)$$

The final weak form of the Glen-Stokes model is the statement that, at the solution $\mathbf{u} \in V_D$ and $p \in Q$, functional F in (28) is zero in all test function directions:

$$F(\mathbf{u}, p; \mathbf{v}, q) = 0 \quad \text{for all } \mathbf{v} \in V_0 \text{ and } q \in Q \quad (29)$$

This weak formulation is proven in [10, Theorem 3.8] to be well-posed, so that a unique solution exists. The theorem in [10] makes reasonable assumptions about the domain Ω and the boundary data, and these are satisfied in the cases we consider. Note that the last two integrals in (28) can be regarded as source terms for stress. In fact, if the inflow velocity is zero and if we replace these source terms by zero—that is if we remove gravity and outflow stresses—then the unique solution to (29) is $\mathbf{u} = 0$ and $p = 0$.

4. FINITE ELEMENT METHOD

This section gives a very abbreviated summary of our finite element (FE) method to solve the glaciological Glen-Stokes equations in weak form (29). Better coverage of FE methods, including for the linear Stokes equations, is in references [4, 5, 6]. The method here uses Firedrake [12]; we do *not* do detailed FE calculations ourselves.

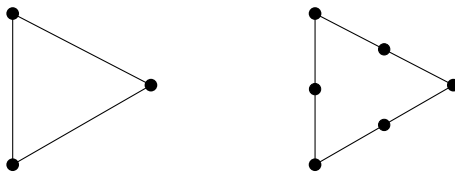
The fundamental FE idea is to replace the infinite-dimensional function spaces appearing in (29) with finite-dimensional subspaces constructed locally from triangles in a mesh. The approximate solution $(\mathbf{u}^h, p^h)$ lives in these subspaces, and the functional F in (28) is computed using test functions from these subspaces. Requiring F to be zero over a basis of the FE test functions, as stated in equation (30) below, defines the (nonlinear) discrete equations. We then ask Firedrake to solve this nonlinear system of algebraic equations using Newton’s method [5].

The mesh itself is denoted $\mathcal{T}_h$. It covers the domain Ω by a finite set of K non-overlapping open elements denoted Δ_k . The mesh is stored in a `.msh` file generated by Gmsh (section 5 below).¹ The subscript “ h ” on $\mathcal{T}_h$ denotes the maximum diameter of the triangles. Let N_1 be the number of element nodes (vertices) in the mesh, including nodes on $\partial\Omega$, and denote the coordinates of the i th node by (x_i, z_i) for $i = 0, 1, \dots, N_1 - 1$.

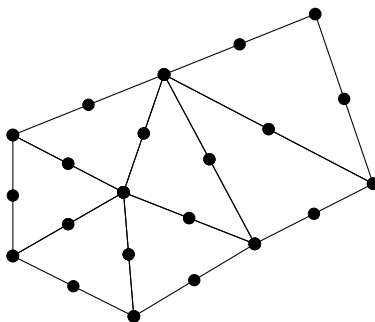
There are various choices of the *finite element space* of low-degree polynomials defined on each triangle. By default we use two particular FE spaces, denoted P_1 for the pressure and $(P_2)^2$ for velocity. Using such paired spaces is called a *mixed method*, and the P_2 - P_1 spaces here are the lowest-order *Taylor-Hood* elements [6].

Consider just one triangle. The name P_1 refers to the space of linear functions $a + bx + cz$ on the triangle. The three vertices of the triangle are the preferred degrees of freedom (Figure 2 left) in the sense that any P_1 function on the triangle is determined by its values at these vertices. The P_2 space, used for each scalar component of the velocity, is the space of quadratic functions $a + bx + cy + dx^2 + exy + fy^2$. For P_2 the preferred six degrees of freedom are the vertices and edge midpoints (Figure 2 right).

¹A slightly-different implementation would extrude a mesh of quadrilaterals.

FIGURE 2. P_1 and P_2 triangular elements.

A continuous scalar function on Ω which is piecewise-linear on each triangle, i.e. in P_1 on each triangle, is determined by its values at the N_1 nodes of the mesh. The space of such functions is a finite-dimensional subspace $Q^h \subset Q$ of the pressure space Q used in the weak form (29). Next, a continuous scalar function on Ω which is piecewise-quadratic (P_2) on each triangle is determined by its values at the nodes *and* edge midpoints in the mesh [6]. Let N_2 denote the number of all such P_2 degrees of freedom, not including Dirichlet boundary nodes. A small mesh is shown in Figure 3, with values for K, N_1, N_2 .

FIGURE 3. A mesh with $K = 7$ triangular elements, $N_1 = 8$ degrees of freedom (nodes) for P_1 , and $N_2 = 22$ degrees of freedom for P_2 .

For the vector-valued velocity functions, V_0^h denotes the space of *pairs* of scalar piecewise-quadratic functions on Ω , additionally required to be zero on the base (10) and inflow (12) Dirichlet boundaries. The functions in V_0^h are 2D vector fields with scalar components which are continuous and piecewise-quadratic scalar functions in P_2 . We define V_D^h to be the same space except satisfying (12) on the inflow boundary. These two P_2 subspaces are used in the FE weak form (30) below: $V_0^h \subset V_0$, $V_D^h \subset V_D$.

A basis of test functions are the *hat functions*.² For pressure, let $\psi_j(x, z)$ be a P_1 hat function from Q^h which is linear on each triangle, continuous on Ω , equal to one at node (x_j, z_j) , and otherwise zero at all other nodes. Thus $\psi_j(x_i, z_i) = \delta_{ij}$. The set $\{\psi_j\}$ is a set of N_1 linearly-independent functions, and thus it is a basis of Q^h . Similarly, for every P_2 node which is not in the base or inflow boundary, whether a triangle vertex or edge midpoint, there is a P_2 hat function. Pairs of such piecewise-quadratic hat functions form a basis of $2N_2$ functions for the velocity test space V_0^h .

When using P_2 elements for velocity and P_1 elements for pressure we see that the dimension $2N_2$ of the velocity space is much higher than the dimension N_1 for the pressure space. However, such a dimension imbalance turns out to be desirable! As explained in the FE literature under the obscure name “inf-sup condition” [4, 5, 6], Stokes equations

²Figure 1.6 in [6] and Figure 10.4 in [5] show P_1 hat functions, while Figure 1.7 in [6] suggests how P_2 hat functions would look.

mixed methods are only stable if the velocity space is sufficiently rich relative to the pressure space.

Finally we can state the FE method itself. It is a finite-dimensional approximation of weak form (29), namely it finds $\mathbf{u}^h \in V_D^h$ and $p^h \in Q^h$ so that

$$F(\mathbf{u}^h, p^h; \mathbf{v}^h, q^h) = 0 \quad \text{for all } \mathbf{v}^h \in V_0^h \text{ and } q^h \in Q^h \quad (30)$$

By linearity of F in its last two arguments, it suffices to consider only the hat function basis of the test function spaces V_0^h and Q^h . Note that relative to (29) the nonlinear functional F is unchanged and we have merely added “ h ” superscripts to all continuum quantities, thus problem (30) can be shown to be well-posed by the same theory that applies to the continuum problem [10, Theorem 4.3].

FE problem (30) is a nonlinear system which should be solved by Newton’s method [5, 11]. To sketch this, suppose we have some current iterate $\mathbf{u}^h, p^h$ which does not exactly solve (30). Then for each test function $\mathbf{v}^h$ or q^h , i.e. for each hat function, the value of the “residual” $F(\mathbf{u}^h, p^h; \mathbf{v}^h, q^h)$ can be computed concretely, though also approximately, by quadrature [5, 6]. Also we can use the current iterate, and the derivatives of F , to evaluate the Jacobian at the current iterate. This “assembly” process³ generates a system of sparse, linear algebraic equations, namely the Newton step equations of the discrete Glen-Stokes problem. Each Newton step requires us to solve a sparse and indefinite linear system. These systems have a well-known block structure (Figure 4), and we may either apply a direct solver for the whole matrix or use a Schur complement preconditioner in a GMRES Krylov iteration [6, 8]. Because solver technology is complicated we abandon further explanation, but see Chapter 14 of [5].

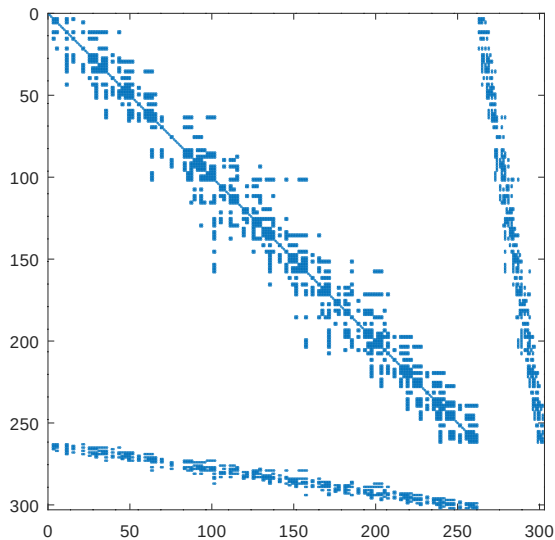


FIGURE 4. Sparsity pattern of the Newton step linear system, when solving the Stokes equations on a coarse mesh ($K = 52, N_1 = 40, N_2 = 131$).

³Actually the equations are assembled element-by-element, not node-by-node. For each triangle $\triangle_k$ the contribution to (30) is added to the correct discrete equation. However, Firedrake hides the assembly process so that we may think about the problem at a higher level [12].

5. IMPLEMENTATION IN PYTHON

This section gives a practical view of our codes and how they are used in practice. In overview, we implement problem (30), and make the stated discretization choices, in Python using Firedrake [12]. The PETSc [3, 5] and Mumps [2] solver libraries are called via Firedrake on the discretized nonlinear equations.

To define the nonlinear residual function F in (28) in code, we apply the UFL domain-specific language, designed for describing such weak forms [1]. This language comes rather close to the mathematical form. Compare (4), (7), and (28) to the following:

```
def D(U):
    return 0.5 * (grad(U) + grad(U).T)
Du2 = 0.5 * inner(D(u), D(u)) + (eps * Dtyp)**2.0
rr = 1.0/3.0 - 1.0
F = ( inner(B3 * Du2**(rr/2.0) * D(u), D(v)) - p * div(v) - div(u) * q ) * dx \
    - inner(f_body, v) * dx - inner(outflow_sigma, v) * ds(bdryids['outflow'])
```

Firedrake knows how to take this code, plus a choice of mesh and function spaces, and run the assemble process to create the Newton step equations for this problem. Then Firedrake's `solve()` command solves (30) [12].

As shown in Figure 5 there are three major Python components:

- **domain.py:** This writes an outline of the domain Ω into an ASCII file (`.geo` extension) using the Gmsh [7] geometry description language. Note Gmsh can be used to mesh this domain at the command-line (below). Portions of the boundary are marked with integer tags; see the Python dictionary `bdryids`.
- **momentummodel.py:** Implements `class MomentumModel`. The physics and equations are isolated here, including physical constants and the weak form (28). The `solve()` method assembles and solves the nonlinear Glen-Stokes problem (29) using Firedrake's `solve()` command. This solver has option prefix `s_`.
- **flow.py:** This driver reads user options, loads the mesh from a Gmsh `.msh` file, uses a `MomentumModel` object to solve the Stokes problem, and writes the solution into a Paraview-readable `.pvd` file.

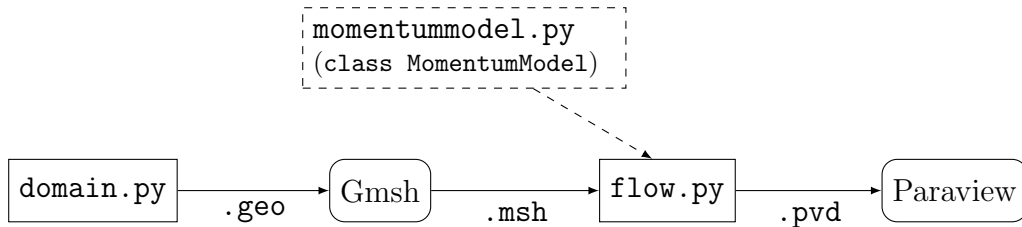


FIGURE 5. Users interact with the tools in order.

Here is a simple example solving the default Stokes problem:

```
$ ./domain.py -o glacier.geo          # create domain outline
$ gmsh -2 glacier.geo                 # mesh domain
```

```

$ source ~/firedrake/bin/activate          # start Firedrake
(firedrake) $ ./flow.py -mesh glacier.msh  # solve Stokes problem
(firedrake) $ paraview output/result.pvd    # visualize results

```

Paraview can be used to generate Figure 1 from the output file. The README.md file documents the usage more thoroughly, including mesh refinement and parallel solutions.

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